

Giraffe and okapi

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Artiodactyla
FAMILY	Giraffidae
SPECIES	5

The giraffe and the okapi are the last surviving representatives of a once highly diverse family. They have long legs, a long, narrow head with small horns, and peculiar, lobed lower canines. The giraffe, with its distinctive long neck, is the tallest living animal—males can reach 18 ft (5.5 m). The

5 species, together known as giraffids, differ in their behavior and ecology because the giraffe lives in woodland savanna (in Africa, south of the Sahara), while the okapi inhabits rain forest (in northeastern Democratic Republic of Congo).

Anatomy

With front legs longer than the back legs, the front parts of the giraffe and the okapi are raised (to facilitate easier browsing). The giraffe has especially long front legs and these are surprisingly sturdy. They are sometimes used in defense: one kick can kill a lion. All species have a long neck, but what is unexpected about the giraffe’s hugely lengthened neck is that it contains only 7 vertebrae, as do almost all other mammals. Each vertebra is greatly elongated, however.

In the giraffe, both sexes have ossicones (horns), while only the male okapi has horns. The horns are different from those found in other mammals in that they form as cartilage, turn to bone from the tips down, and are covered with skin.

Giraffids have a thick hide to help ward off predators. The okapi has a velvety, dark brown coat with white stripes on the haunches and upper

legs (the legs are white below the knees). Giraffes have spotted coats, the pattern of which varies according to location. Both species have a long, copiously tufted tail.

Feeding

Giraffids are browsers with unique 2- or 3-lobed canine teeth, which can be used like a comb to strip leaves from small branches. They also use their thin, mobile lips and long black tongue—which can be extended more than 18 in (45 cm) in giraffes—to gather leaves and shoots. They have a 4-chambered, ruminating stomach (see p.211). Male giraffes tend to be taller than females and are therefore able to feed at higher levels.

Social groups

The giraffe and the okapi have contrasting social systems. Giraffes have home ranges of, on average,

approximately 62 square miles (160 square km). When these overlap (which is often), loose associations of up to 25 individuals form. The composition of these herds changes daily. Males are nonterritorial, but a dominance hierarchy is determined in a ritualized fight called “necking”—2 adult males stand side by side, alternately swinging their heads and hitting each other on the neck. Male giraffes have extra bone all over the skull, which provides reinforcement. Only males of high social standing have the right to mate.

Okapis, on the other hand, are mainly solitary animals and are never found in herds. They have much smaller home ranges, and only the dominant males maintain a territory (females move freely from one territory to the next). Male okapis mate with females that wander through their territory.



SWIFT RUNNERS

When danger threatens, a giraffe will take flight, leading others nearby to follow suit. These Angolan giraffes (*G. c. angolensis*) can reach speeds of over 31 mph (50 kph). Giraffes move directly from a walk to a gallop because their long legs and short body make trotting impossible without tripping.